

SOLVE IT ONCE. PREVENT IT EVERYWHERE.

Most problems in your plant have already been solved, just not in your building. Yokoten is the Toyota Production System practice of spreading a proven fix **sideways**: to every line, shift, product and site where the same failure could happen. It is not a memo. It is a pull system for lessons.

Yoko 横 Sideways

Ten 展 Spread

横展開 *Yokotenkai*, the full term: horizontal deployment

1 Capture the why, not just the fix

- Write down the mechanism that caused the failure, the countermeasure, the evidence it worked, and the conditions it depends on.

Trap: sharing only the fix (“we changed the setting”). Without the cause, the next site copies it where it doesn’t apply.

OUTPUT

A one-page lesson card (worksheet A).

2 Ask “Where else?”

- Scan for the same failure mode, not the same part number: same equipment type, process step, material, procedure, design feature or training.

Trap: checking only identical machines. The same cause hides behind a different address.

OUTPUT

A ranked “where else” list with an owner for each place.

3 Go and see, then adapt

- The receiving team visits the gemba where it worked (or walks it on video), compares conditions with their own, and adapts the fix.

Trap: copy and paste. Different conditions turn a good fix into a new problem.

OUTPUT

A local adaptation with an owner and a date.

4 Make it a pull, not a push

- Give lessons a standing slot in existing reviews, and have leaders ask “what did we learn elsewhere?” Recognise the teams that adopt, not only the team that solved.

Trap: one email to every site that nobody owns or reads.

OUTPUT

A regular forum where lessons are requested, not sent.

5 Close the loop

- Track every place on the list to a decision: implemented and verified, or not applicable with a reason. Then change the standard so the lesson outlives the people.

Trap: calling it done when the email is sent.

OUTPUT

An adoption tracker closed out and the standard updated (worksheet B).

In a regulated plant you already ask this question: it is the “extent of condition” or impact assessment in a CAPA. Which other products, lines, batches or sites share the cause? Yokoten turns that question from a box on a form into a habit.



SAME FAILURE, DIFFERENT ADDRESS

Searching for the identical machine finds the obvious copies and misses the rest. Search by what caused the failure: each lens is a different way the same cause can show up elsewhere.

THE “WHERE ELSE?” LENSES

LENS	WHERE TO LOOK	THE QUESTION TO ASK
Equipment	Same machine type, tool, fixture or vendor model	Does it have the same weak point, even if it runs a different product?
Process step	The same operation on other lines, shifts and sites	Is the step done the same way, with the same checks?
Material	Same supplier, grade, component or packaging	Could the same input variation reach this line?
Document	Procedures, batch records, work instructions built from the same template	Does the same unclear step appear here?
Design	Products or parts that share the feature that failed	Is the same tolerance, interface or feature used elsewhere?
People	Roles trained with the same course or on-the-job method	Were they taught the same gap?

REVIEW RHYTHM

WHEN	WHO	LOOKS AT
Daily	Team huddle	Lessons from elsewhere that touch today's work
Weekly	Area review	5 minutes: lessons in, lessons out
Monthly	Site leaders	The adoption tracker: what is stalled, and why
Quarterly	Network / sites	Top lessons shared, and standards changed

MAKE IT STICK

- **Use the reviews you already have.** A new meeting is the first one people skip.
- **Ask, don't send.** Leaders asking “what did we learn elsewhere?” creates the pull.
- **Credit the adopter.** Copying a good fix fast is a skill. Recognise it.
- **Make “not applicable” earn its place** with a reason someone else could check.
- **Change the standard:** procedure, FMEA, control plan or design rule. If only people know it, it leaves with them.

ADOPTION STATUS, FOR EVERY PLACE ON THE LIST

Not started Assessed Not applicable (with reason)

Implemented Verified effective

SELF-CHECK: SIGNS YOUR LESSONS ARE NOT TRAVELLING

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ The same deviation shows up at a second site | ☐ “Not applicable” is ticked with no reason |
| ☐ Corrective actions close on retraining alone | ☐ A standard was updated at one site only |
| ☐ Sites hear about a fix by accident | ☐ Nobody owns a lesson once it leaves its team |

Three or more ticks? Start with your last closed CAPA: fill in worksheet A, then run the “where else?” scan.



THE LESSON CARD: CAPTURE THE WHY

One card per lesson. Write it so a team at another site, who has never met you, could decide whether it applies to them.

LESSON TITLE

WHERE IT HAPPENED · WHEN · CONTACT

1 · THE PROBLEM

What happened, where, how often, how big.

2 · THE ROOT CAUSE

The mechanism. "Human error" is where the investigation stopped.

3 · THE COUNTERMEASURE

What changed, and why it removes the cause.

4 · EVIDENCE IT WORKED

Before and after, over what period.

5 · CONDITIONS IT DEPENDS ON

Equipment, material, volume, skills it needs.

6 · STANDARD CHANGED

The procedure, FMEA or control plan that changed.

"WHERE ELSE?" SCAN

LENS	WHERE THE SAME CAUSE COULD SHOW UP	RISK H/M/L	OWNER	CHECK BY
Equipment				
Process step				
Material				
Document				
Design				
People				

THE ADOPTION TRACKER: CLOSE THE LOOP

One row for every place on your “where else?” list. Review it monthly. A row is closed only when it is verified effective, or “not applicable” with a reason someone else could check.

LINE / SITE	OWNER	APPLIES? IF NOT, WHY	ADAPTED HOW	DONE (DATE)	VERIFIED: EVIDENCE

CLOSE-THE-LOOP CHECK

- ☐ Every place on the list has a status
- ☐ Every “not applicable” has a reason
- ☐ Effectiveness checked with data, not a signature
- ☐ The standard is updated everywhere it applies
- ☐ Other teams can find the lesson card
- ☐ The team that adopted it fastest was recognised

START THIS WEEK

Take your last closed CAPA. Ask: where else could this happen? Name three places, then go and look.

#	PLACE	LOOKED ON
1		
2		
3		



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